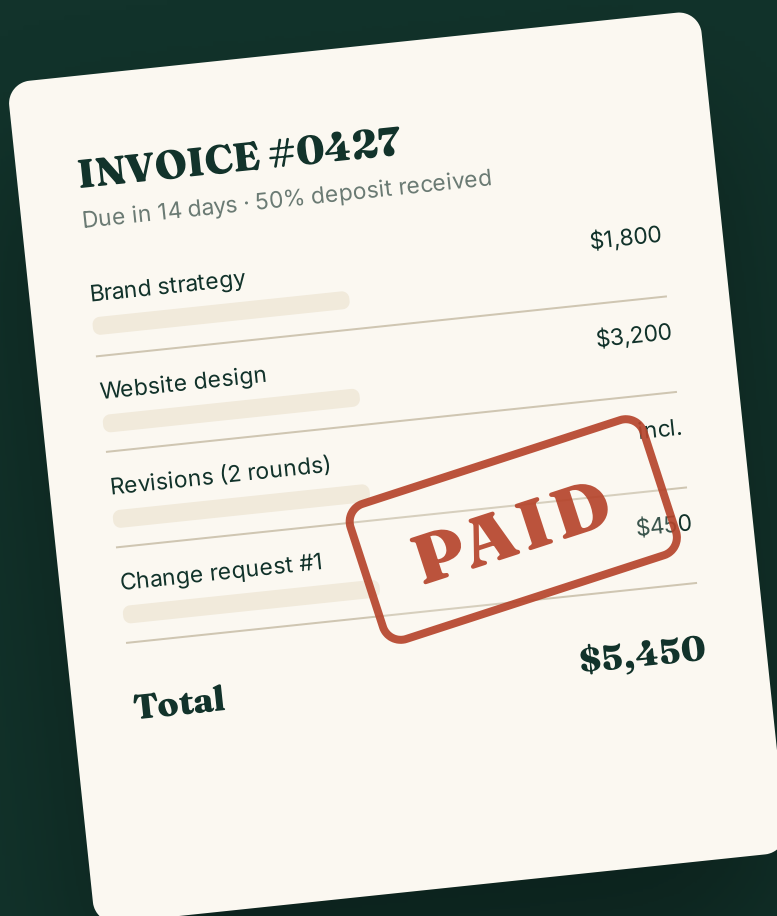


Paid in *Full.*

Charge what you're worth, stop scope creep, and get every invoice paid — on time.

35+
scripts,
worksheets &
templates



Welcome. Let's fix the money part.

You're good at the work. This playbook is for everything around it — the quoting, the awkward emails, the chasing — so the work actually pays.

Most freelancers lose money in three places, and none of them have anything to do with talent:

1 • Underpricing

Rates picked by gut feel or copied from someone else, instead of calculated from what you actually need to earn.

2 • Scope creep

"Just one more small thing" — repeated until a fixed-price project turns into unpaid overtime.

3 • Late payment

Unclear terms, no deposit, and no follow-up system — so invoices drift 30, 60, 90 days.

Each part of this playbook closes one of those leaks with something you can **use today**: a worksheet to fill in, a checklist to tick, or a word-for-word script to copy and adapt.

How to use this playbook

- ☐ **Short on time? Do the 30-minute version.** Fill in the Minimum Rate worksheet (p. 5) and copy the payment-terms block (p. 14) into your next quote.
- ☐ **Want the full reset?** Follow the 7-Day Action Plan (p. 17). About 30–45 minutes a day.
- ☐ **Stuck in a situation right now?** Jump straight to the script you need — objections (p. 9), rate increases (p. 10), scope creep (p. 13), late payments (p. 15).

About the scripts

Every script has **[brackets]** for the parts you personalise. Read them out loud once before using them — then change any wording that doesn't sound like you. The structure matters more than the exact words.

Print it (A4, "Background graphics" on) or fill it in on a tablet. Everything here is general business guidance, not legal, tax or financial advice — see the note on p. 20.

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The three money leaks

Before changing anything, find out where your money is actually going. Answer honestly — nobody sees this but you.

Leak 1 — Underpricing

- ☐ I set my rate by looking at what others charge, or by what "felt reasonable."
- ☐ I haven't raised my rates in over 12 months.
- ☐ I don't know how many hours a year I actually bill.
- ☐ I usually discount when a client hesitates on price.

Leak 2 — Scope creep

- ☐ My quotes don't list exactly what's included — and what isn't.
- ☐ I don't cap revision rounds.
- ☐ I've done "small extras" for free in the last 3 months.
- ☐ I finish fixed-price projects and realise my hourly rate was far lower than planned.

Leak 3 — Late payment

- ☐ I start work without a deposit.
- ☐ My invoices don't show a clear due date and late-payment terms.
- ☐ I feel awkward chasing money, so I wait too long to follow up.
- ☐ At least one invoice is overdue right now.

Your biggest leak

Count the ticks in each section. The one with the most ticks is where to start — go straight to that part of the playbook.

Underpricing: _____ / 4

Scope creep: _____ / 4

Late payment: _____ / 4



Your Minimum Rate

This is your **floor** — the hourly rate below which freelancing costs you money compared with a salary. You'll price most work *above* it. Use yearly figures in your own currency. The grey column shows a worked example.

A	Take-home pay you want per year (what you'd need from a salary)	e.g. 48,000	
B	Business costs per year — software, equipment, insurance, accountant, co-working, phone	6,000	
C	Savings buffer: pension, sick days, quiet months (suggest 10–20% of A)	7,200	
D	Estimated income tax & social contributions as a % of profit (ask your accountant or use your last return)	30%	
E	Revenue needed = $(A + C) \div (1 - D) + B$	84,857	

Now, your real billable hours

F	Weeks you'll work per year (52 minus holidays, public holidays, sick days)	44	
G	Hours you work per week	40	
H	% of that time that's <i>billable</i> — not admin, sales, email, learning (many freelancers land around 50–70%)	60%	
I	Billable hours per year = $F \times G \times H$	1,056	
★	Your minimum hourly rate = $E \div I$	80.36	

Day rate

Minimum hourly × billable hours per day ($G \times H \div 5$).

My minimum day rate: _____

Reality check

Your current rate: _____

Gap vs. minimum: _____

Why D is divided, not added: tax is charged on profit, so you need to earn enough that what's *left after tax* equals your target. Dividing by $(1 - D)$ does that. It's an estimate — check the real figure with a local accountant. **Prefer a spreadsheet?** The bonus calculator does every step automatically.



Project Quote Builder

Clients prefer a fixed price; you need that price to protect your hourly rate. Break the project into phases, estimate honestly, then add the buffers most freelancers forget.

Project: _____ Client: _____

PHASE / DELIVERABLE	BEST-CASE HRS	LIKELY HRS	WORST-CASE HRS
e.g. Discovery call + brief	2	3	5
Project management, calls, email			
Totals			

- Estimated hours = (Best + 4 × Likely + Worst) ÷ 6 — a weighted "three-point" estimate
- Risk buffer: +10% for clear projects, +20–30% for new clients, vague briefs or new types of work
- Your rate for this project (at or above your minimum rate)
- Direct costs you'll pay (stock, fonts, plugins, subcontractors)
- ★ **Base price = (1 + buffer) × rate + costs**

The value check — before you send it

Hours set your *floor*, not your ceiling. Ask:

- What is this worth to the client? (More leads, time saved, a launch, a fixed problem.)

- Is it urgent, high-stakes, or something only a few people can do well? If yes, price higher.
- Would I be *happy* doing this at this price in month three of the project? If not, raise it.

Final quoted price: _____ Effective hourly: _____



Good / Better / Best

Offering one price invites a yes/no decision. Offering three turns it into a *which one?* decision, and gives budget-conscious clients a way in without you cutting your rate. Build the middle option first — it's the one you want most clients to pick.

Good	Better target	Best
The essential result — nothing extra	Everything in Good, plus what most clients actually need	Premium: faster, more support, more done-for-you
Includes	Includes	Includes
_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____
Revisions / timeline	Revisions / timeline	Revisions / timeline
_____	_____	_____
PRICE	PRICE	PRICE

Rules that make packages work

- ☐ **Never price "Good" below your minimum rate.** It's the cheapest option, not a discount.
Remove scope to reach a lower price — don't cut your rate.
- ☐ **Make the jump from Good to Better obvious value.** Add the thing clients most often ask for later (e.g. a second revision round, handover call, copy for the page).
- ☐ **Price "Best" noticeably higher** — often around 2–3× Good. A few clients will take it; for everyone else it makes "Better" look reasonable.
- ☐ **Differentiate with speed, access and done-for-you** — not just "more of the same."
- ☐ **Write outcomes, not tasks** — "a homepage ready to launch" beats "design 1 page in Figma."



The one-page proposal

Long proposals rarely win because they're long. A clear page that shows you understood the problem does. Copy this structure into your own document.

1 · THEIR SITUATION

2-3 SENTENCES

"You told me [the problem in their words]. Right now that means [cost: lost leads / hours wasted / delayed launch]. You'd like to [goal] by [date]."

2 · THE OUTCOME

1 SENTENCE

"By [date], you'll have [specific, visible result] so that [business benefit]."

3 · HOW WE'LL GET THERE

3-5 STEPS

Step 1 — [Discovery / kickoff] · Step 2 — [First draft] · Step 3 — [Review & revise] · Step 4 — [Launch / handover]

4 · YOUR OPTIONS

PASTE YOUR 3 PACKAGES

Good — [price] · **Better — [price] (recommended)** · Best — [price]

5 · WHAT'S INCLUDED — AND WHAT ISN'T

THE ANTI-SCOPE-CREEP LINE

Included: [deliverables], [number] rounds of revisions, [support period].

Not included: [e.g. copywriting, stock photos, ongoing maintenance] — available at [rate] if needed.

6 · TERMS & NEXT STEP

MAKE YES EASY

[50]% deposit to book your start date, balance due [14] days after delivery. This proposal is valid until [date].

"To go ahead, just reply 'yes' with the option you'd like, and I'll send the agreement and deposit invoice today."

Send it fast: a proposal that lands within a day or two of the call, while the conversation is fresh, feels more professional than a perfect one a week later. **Follow up** after 3 working days if you hear nothing (script on the next page).



Saying your price out loud

The rule: state the number, then stop talking. No apology, no explaining, no "but I'm flexible." Silence is not a no.

STATING THE PRICE

"For everything we discussed, the investment is [price]. That includes [top 2 inclusions]."

"THAT'S MORE THAN WE EXPECTED."

"Thanks for being upfront. What budget did you have in mind? If it's [lower number], I'd suggest the [Good] option — here's what we'd leave out to get there."

Change the scope, never the rate.

"SOMEONE ELSE QUOTED LESS."

"That makes sense — prices vary a lot. It's worth comparing exactly what's included: [revisions / timeline / support]. If theirs covers the same and you're comfortable with it, go for it. If you'd like [your differentiator], I'm here."

"CAN YOU DO IT FOR LESS?"

"I can do it for less by doing less. For [lower price] I can deliver [reduced scope]. Would that work?"

"WE'LL PAY YOU IN EXPOSURE / FUTURE WORK."

"I appreciate that — and I'd love to work together long-term. For this first project my rate is [price]; if there's ongoing work later we can talk about a retainer."

"LET ME THINK ABOUT IT." — FOLLOW-UP AFTER 3 WORKING DAYS

"Hi [name], just checking in on the proposal for [project]. Happy to answer any questions or adjust the scope to fit. I'm booking [month] projects this week — would you like me to hold a spot for you?"

Only mention limited availability if it's true.



Raising your rates

New clients get your new rate immediately. Existing clients get **notice** — around 30–60 days is a courteous norm — and a clear date. You don't need to justify it at length; a short, confident note reads better than a long apology.

EMAIL A · STANDARD NOTICE

EXISTING CLIENTS

Subject: Update to my rates from [date]

Hi [name],

I've really enjoyed working with you on [project/work] — thank you. I'm writing to let you know that from [date, 30–60 days out], my rate for new work will be [new rate].

Anything booked before that date stays at the current rate. If you have work coming up, now is a good time to schedule it.

Looking forward to what's next,
[Your name]

EMAIL B · WITH A LOYALTY BRIDGE

LONG-TERM / RETAINER CLIENTS

Hi [name],

Quick heads-up: from [date] my standard rate goes up to [new rate]. Because you've been with me for [time], your rate will move to [in-between rate] for the next [3/6] months, then to the standard rate on [date].

Thanks for being such a great client — happy to jump on a call if you'd like to talk it through.

IF THEY PUSH BACK

"I understand. This new rate reflects [the results we've delivered / the demand I'm seeing]. If the budget is fixed, we could adjust the scope — for example [smaller monthly scope] at the new rate."

Before you send

- ☐ New rate decided and written down: _____ (from p. 5)
- ☐ Website, rate card and proposal template updated first
- ☐ Effective date is at least 30 days away and written in every email
- ☐ Logged the change in your Rate Review (p. 20)



Contract essentials

You don't need a 20-page contract, but you do need these points in writing **before** work starts. Use this list to check the agreement you already have — or to brief a lawyer.

- ☐ **Parties & contact person**
Who the client is legally, and who can approve work and sign off.

- ☐ **Scope of work**
Specific deliverables, formats and quantities — ideally attached from your proposal.

- ☐ **Exclusions**
What is explicitly not included.

- ☐ **Revisions**
Number of rounds included, and the rate for extra rounds.

- ☐ **Change requests**
How new requests are quoted and approved in writing before work starts.

- ☐ **Timeline & client responsibilities**
Deadlines depend on the client supplying feedback and materials on time.

- ☐ **Fees, deposit & payment schedule**
Total price, deposit %, milestones, due dates, accepted payment methods, currency.

- ☐ **Late payment terms**
Interest or fees (within what your local law allows) and the right to pause work.

- ☐ **Ownership / licence of the work**
Rights usually transfer on full payment. State it clearly.

- ☐ **Portfolio rights**
Whether you can show the work publicly, and when.

- ☐ **Confidentiality**
What both sides keep private.

- ☐ **Cancellation / kill fee**
What's owed if the client stops the project midway (e.g. work done to date, deposit non-refundable).

- ☐ **Limitation of liability**
Commonly capped at the fees paid for the project.

- ☐ **Independent contractor status**
You're a business, not an employee.

- ☐ **Signatures & date**
A reply email saying "I agree" is better than nothing; a signed document is better still.

Important: this checklist is general information, not legal advice. Contract and late-payment rules differ by country and state — have a local lawyer review your template once. It's a small, one-off cost next to a single unpaid invoice.

Onboarding & red flags



Onboarding: before any work starts

- ☐ Proposal accepted in writing (option chosen)
- ☐ Contract signed
- ☐ Deposit invoice sent
- ☐ **Deposit received** — work starts now, not before
- ☐ Billing contact & invoice details confirmed (company name, tax ID, PO number if needed)
- ☐ Kickoff call booked
- ☐ All materials & access received (logins, brand files, content)
- ☐ Single decision-maker agreed
- ☐ Feedback channel agreed (one email thread / one tool)
- ☐ Milestones & feedback dates in both calendars
- ☐ Welcome email sent (below)

Red flags: slow down if you see...

- ☐ "It's a quick job" — before you've seen the brief
- ☐ Asks for free samples or "a small test" of real work
- ☐ Resists a deposit or a written agreement
- ☐ Talks badly about every previous freelancer
- ☐ Can't say who makes the final decision
- ☐ Deadline is "yesterday" but feedback is slow
- ☐ Negotiates hard on price before discussing the work
- ☐ Scope keeps growing during the sales call

2+ red flags? Raise the risk buffer (p. 6), ask for a larger deposit (50–100%), and keep scope tight — or politely decline.

WELCOME EMAIL

SEND ONCE THE DEPOSIT LANDS

Hi [name] — deposit received, thank you! We're officially booked. Here's what happens next: **[date]** kickoff call · **[date]** first draft · **[date]** your feedback · **[date]** final delivery. To keep us on schedule, please send [materials] by [date]. All feedback in this thread, please, so nothing gets lost. Excited to get started!

6 questions for every discovery call

1. What made you look for help with this *now*?
2. What does success look like in 3 months?
3. What happens if this doesn't get done?
4. Who else is involved in the decision?
5. What's your timeline — and what's driving it?
6. Have you set aside a budget range for this?



Stopping scope creep — politely

Scope creep is rarely malicious; clients often don't know where the line is. Your job is to show them the line, kindly, **every time** — and make it easy to say yes to paying for the extra.

THE SMALL EXTRA REQUEST

"Happy to help with that! It's outside what we agreed for this project, so I'll send a quick quote — it'd be [price] and add [time]. Want me to go ahead?"

THE "WHILE YOU'RE AT IT..."

"Great idea. Let's finish [current deliverable] first so we stay on schedule, then I'll quote [new item] as a phase 2."

REVISION ROUNDS USED UP

"We've now used the [2] revision rounds included. I'm glad to keep refining — additional rounds are [price] each. Shall I go ahead with round [3]?"

A BIG CHANGE IN DIRECTION

"This is a different direction from the brief we signed off on [date], so it's a new piece of work rather than a revision. I'll send an updated quote and timeline today."

THE ONE FREE FAVOUR (ON PURPOSE)

"I've gone ahead and done [small thing] at no charge this time. Just so you know for the future, requests like this are normally [price]."

Use once, deliberately — it builds goodwill *and* sets the boundary.

Change request mini-form — paste into your email

Request: _____ · Extra cost: _____ · Extra time: _____ · New delivery date: _____ · Approved by: _____ (reply "approved" to confirm)

Payment terms & invoices



Most late payments are prevented **before** the invoice is sent — by clear terms agreed at the start and an invoice the client's accounts team can pay without asking a single question.

Copy-paste payment terms — for proposals & contracts

- A non-refundable deposit of [30–50]% is due before work begins and secures your start date.
- For projects over [X weeks / amount]: [25]% at [milestone], balance on delivery.
- Invoices are due within [7 / 14] days of the invoice date.
- Late payments may incur [interest / a late fee] as permitted by law, and work may be paused until the account is up to date.
- Final files and ownership rights transfer once the invoice is paid in full.

The "no questions" invoice checklist

- | | |
|--|--|
| ☐ Unique invoice number | ☐ Deposit already paid, shown as deducted |
| ☐ Invoice date <i>and</i> due date (a date, not "Net 14") | ☐ Tax/VAT shown correctly for your country |
| ☐ Your legal/business name, address & tax ID | ☐ Total and currency — in bold |
| ☐ Client's legal company name & billing address | ☐ Payment details / pay-online link |
| ☐ PO or reference number if they use one | ☐ Late payment terms (one line) |
| ☐ Clear line items matching the proposal | ☐ Sent to the billing contact, cc your project contact |

Shorter terms get paid sooner. If you currently use 30 days, try 14 — or 7 for small invoices. Many clients simply pay on whatever date is printed.

Make paying effortless. A card or online-payment link removes an excuse. Factor the processing fee into your prices rather than surprising clients with it.

"WHY DO YOU NEED A DEPOSIT?"

"It's standard for how I work — the deposit reserves your start date, so I can turn down other projects for that time. It's credited in full against the final invoice."



The late-payment sequence

Put these in your calendar the moment you send an invoice. Following a system means you never have to decide *whether* it's "too soon" to chase — and the tone stays friendly, then firm, never emotional.

STEP 1 · FRIENDLY REMINDER

3 DAYS BEFORE DUE DATE

Subject: Invoice [#] due on [date]

Hi [name], a quick friendly reminder that invoice [#] for [amount] is due on [date]. I've attached it again here for convenience, and you can pay by [method / link]. Thanks so much!

STEP 2 · DUE-DATE NUDGE

1 DAY AFTER DUE DATE

Subject: Invoice [#] — payment due yesterday

Hi [name], I hope all's well. Invoice [#] for [amount] was due yesterday, [date], and I haven't seen payment come through yet. Could you let me know when it's scheduled? If it's already been sent, please ignore this — and thank you!

STEP 3 · DIRECT FOLLOW-UP

7 DAYS OVERDUE

Subject: Overdue: invoice [#] ([amount])

Hi [name], invoice [#] for [amount] is now 7 days overdue. Could you confirm the payment date by [day]?

If there's an issue with the invoice or something I can clarify, just let me know — I'm happy to help sort it out. If it's easier, I can also speak to your accounts team directly: who's the best person to contact?

Between the steps

- **Ask a question** in every email ("when is it scheduled?") — questions get replies; statements get ignored.
- **Find the payer.** Your project contact often isn't the person who pays. Ask for accounts payable by step 3.
- **Pick up the phone** after step 3. A 2-minute call often achieves what three emails didn't.

THE 2-MINUTE PHONE CALL

AFTER STEP 3

"Hi [name], it's [you] — quick call about invoice [#]. It's now [X] days overdue and I want to make sure it hasn't got stuck somewhere. Is there anything holding it up on your side? ... Great — what date can I expect it?"

Then send a one-line email confirming the date they gave you.

When it gets serious

By now, stay polite but make the consequences clear — and only mention consequences you're actually prepared to follow through on.

STEP 4 · FIRM NOTICE + PAUSE

14 DAYS OVERDUE

Subject: Action needed: invoice [#] 14 days overdue

Hi [name], invoice [#] for [amount] is now 14 days overdue and I haven't received a payment date. As set out in our agreement, I'll be pausing work on [project] from [date] until the account is up to date, and [late fee / interest] now applies.

I'd much rather keep things moving — please arrange payment or reply with a date by [date].

STEP 5 · FINAL NOTICE

30 DAYS OVERDUE

Subject: Final notice: invoice [#]

Hi [name], this is a final notice for invoice [#] for [amount plus any fees], now 30 days overdue despite reminders on [dates].

If payment isn't received by [date — 7 days out], I'll need to take the next step to recover it, which may include [a formal letter of demand / a collections service / a small-claims process]. I'd much prefer to settle this directly — please get in touch today.

OFFERING A PAYMENT PLAN

WHEN THEY GENUINELY CAN'T PAY

"I understand things are tight. Could we split the balance into [2–3] payments of [amount] on [dates]? If you confirm in writing today, I'll hold off on any late fees."

Know your local rules

Late-payment rights depend on where you and your client are. One example: in the UK, the *Late Payment of Commercial Debts (Interest) Act 1998* lets businesses claim statutory interest (8% above the Bank of England base rate) plus fixed compensation of £40–£100 per invoice on late business-to-business payments. Other countries and US states have different rules.

My local rules (fill in once): _____

Before any formal step: keep a simple paper trail — the signed agreement, the invoice, and every reminder with its date. Whatever route you choose later (a formal demand letter, a collections agency, or a small-claims court), you'll need it.



7-Day Action Plan

About 30–45 minutes a day. By day 7 your pricing, paperwork and payment system are rebuilt — and your next client gets the new version of you.

- ☐ **Day 1 · Diagnose & calculate.** Take the Three Leaks check (p. 4). Fill in your Minimum Rate (p. 5). Write your new rate on a sticky note.
Output: minimum hourly & day rate.

- ☐ **Day 2 · Package.** Build Good / Better / Best for your most common project (p. 7). Price each with the Quote Builder (p. 6).
Output: three priced packages.

- ☐ **Day 3 · Proposal.** Turn the one-page proposal (p. 8) into your own reusable template with your packages and payment terms.
Output: proposal template saved.

- ☐ **Day 4 · Contract.** Check your agreement against the 15 essentials (p. 11). Note gaps; book a lawyer review if needed.
Output: contract gaps listed / fixed.

- ☐ **Day 5 · Payment system.** Update your invoice template (p. 14), shorten terms, add a pay-online option. Save the 5 late-payment emails as templates (pp. 15–16).
Output: invoice + email templates ready.

- ☐ **Day 6 · Clean up the past.** List every unpaid invoice in the tracker (p. 18) and send the right step of the sequence for each one.
Output: every overdue invoice chased.

- ☐ **Day 7 · Raise & commit.** Update your website/rate card. Send rate-increase notices if needed (p. 10). Set a calendar reminder for a rate review in 6 months.
Output: new rates live.

My commitment

From _____ I will quote no less than _____ per hour, take a deposit on every project, and follow my payment sequence without apologising.

Signed: _____

Client & invoice tracker



One row per invoice. Check it every Monday — anything past its due date gets the next step of the sequence. Print as many copies as you need.

CLIENT	INV #	AMOUNT	SENT	DUE	CHASE STEP (1-5)	PAID ✓ / DATE
					① ② ③ ④ ⑤	
					① ② ③ ④ ⑤	
					① ② ③ ④ ⑤	
					① ② ③ ④ ⑤	
					① ② ③ ④ ⑤	
					① ② ③ ④ ⑤	
					① ② ③ ④ ⑤	
					① ② ③ ④ ⑤	
					① ② ③ ④ ⑤	
					① ② ③ ④ ⑤	
					① ② ③ ④ ⑤	
					① ② ③ ④ ⑤	
					① ② ③ ④ ⑤	
					① ② ③ ④ ⑤	
					① ② ③ ④ ⑤	
					① ② ③ ④ ⑤	
					① ② ③ ④ ⑤	

Chase schedule: ① 3 days before due · ② 1 day after · ③ 7 days after · ④ 14 days after · ⑤ 30 days after.

12-month income dashboard

115

Fill in at the end of each month. The **effective hourly** column is the truth-teller: $\text{invoiced} \div \text{hours actually worked (billable and non-billable)}$. If it's below your minimum rate, look at scope creep first.

Year: _____ Revenue target (E, p. 5): _____ Monthly target ($\div 12$): _____

MONTH	INVOICED	RECEIVED	HOURS WORKED	EFFECTIVE HOURLY	VS. TARGET	NOTE
Jan					▲ ▼	
Feb					▲ ▼	
Mar					▲ ▼	
Apr					▲ ▼	
May					▲ ▼	
Jun					▲ ▼	
Jul					▲ ▼	
Aug					▲ ▼	
Sep					▲ ▼	
Oct					▲ ▼	
Nov					▲ ▼	
Dec					▲ ▼	
Total						

Best month

Best client (by effective hourly)

One change for next year

Rate review & wins log



Rate review — every 6 months

DATE	OLD RATE	NEW RATE	WHY

--	--	--	--

Signs it's time: you're fully booked, clients say yes instantly, or your effective hourly is below your minimum.

Wins log

Every quote you didn't discount, every invoice paid on time, every boundary held. Read this list before your next price conversation.

"Clear terms are a kindness — to your clients and to you."

Charging properly and getting paid on time isn't greed. It's what lets you keep doing good work for the people who hire you. Come back to this playbook whenever a new situation shows up — the right script is usually already in here.

Notes

Disclaimer. This playbook provides general business information and templates for educational purposes. It is not legal, tax, accounting or financial advice, and it doesn't create any professional relationship. Laws on contracts, invoicing, tax and late payment vary by country and state — consult a qualified professional before relying on any template. Results depend on your market, skills and circumstances; no specific income outcome is promised.

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